CYBERSECURITY TRAINING HANDBOOK

SEMESTER 3 (ELITE TRACK)

DOCUMENT CONTROL

Owner:	Yiga Elvis
Document:	Semester 3 Elite Training Handbook
Version:	v1.0 (Generated)
Date:	March 04, 2026
Outcome:	Elite portfolio + specialization mastery
Policy:	Authorized labs only. No real-world targeting.

1. Purpose (Elite Track)

Semester 3 is the elite track. The objective is specialization mastery plus senior-level communication: client-quality reports, architecture documents, detection content packs, and complete case files. All work must remain lab-only unless you have written authorization.

Elite Outcomes (End of Semester 3)

- Flagship portfolio: 3 major case files (SOC/IR, DFIR, Architecture) and 2 content packs (Detection/YARA).
- Ability to brief leadership: executive briefs, metrics, risk registers, and architecture diagrams.
- Demonstrated specialization: Cloud Security or DFIR or Detection Engineering or AppSec/Architecture.
- Professional habits: tuning, metrics, runbooks, evidence integrity, and repeatable processes.

2. Ethics, Authorization, and Safe Practice

This handbook does not authorize real-world intrusion. Any adversary concepts are for defense validation only. Do not scan or test any system you do not own or control. Written authorization is required.

Non-Negotiable Rules

- Lab-only unless written authorization (scope + permission).
- No targeting public systems. No bypassing controls in real environments.
- Maintain evidence integrity: timestamps, hashes, chain-of-evidence discipline.
- Stop when scope is unclear.

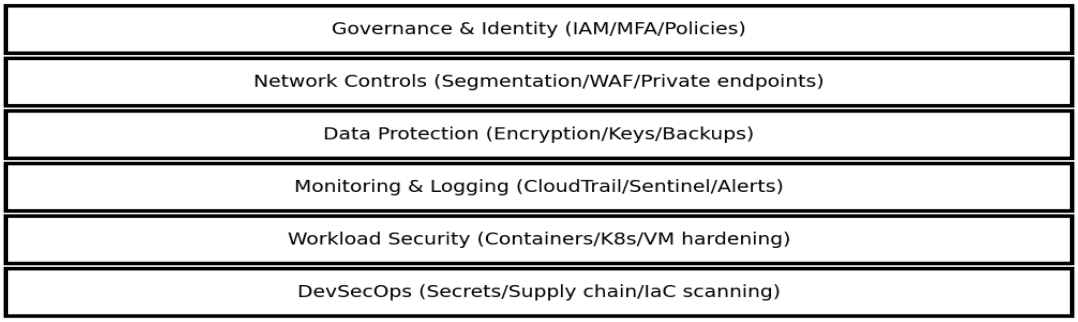
3. Elite Reference Diagrams

Print these. Elite professionals explain systems using clear frameworks.

Detection Engineering Lifecycle (Elite Habit)

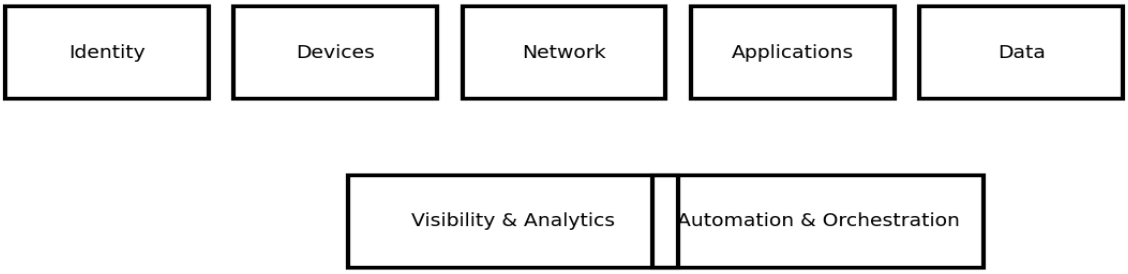
Deliverables: queries/rules + runbooks + tuning notes + metrics (precision/coverage/MTTR).

Cloud Security Layers (Elite Baseline)



Deliverables: baseline checklists + architecture diagrams + logging matrix + response playbooks.

Zero Trust (Pillars You Must Speak About in Interviews)



Principles: verify explicitly • least privilege • assume breach • continuous monitoring.

4. Semester 3 Course Outline (Weeks 53–78)

Month	Week	Theme	Primary Artifact
Month 13	Week 53	Endpoint Telemetry Deep Dive: Sysmon Config + Windows Security Logging	Sysmon config + log export script + ev
Month 13	Week 54	Network Detections: Zeek/Suricata Tuning + Enrichment Concepts	Network detection notes + IOC table + tunin
Month 13	Week 55	Detection Engineering II: Correlation, Severity Rubric, Runbooks	Detection pack v2 (5 detections + runbooks
Month 13	Week 56	SOAR & Automation: Playbooks, APIs, Case Management (Concepts + Build)	Mini-SOAR playbook pack + automation scri
Month 14	Week 57	Threat Hunting II: Baselining, Hypothesis Hunts, Evidence Tables	Hunt pack (2 hunts + gap analysis)
Month 14	Week 58	Threat Hunting III: Lateral Movement Indicators (Defensive Focus)	Lateral movement defense pack (detections
Month 14	Week 59	Incident Response Advanced: Crisis Comms, Severity, War Room Discipline	IR war room pack: timeline + decision log +
Month 14	Week 60	SOC/IR Capstone: Full Case File (Alert → Investigation → Report)	SOC/IR Case File v2 (10–20 pages + evider
Month 15	Week 61	Windows DFIR Advanced: Persistence & Artifact Deep Dive (Defensive)	DFIR artifact checklist + timeline report
Month 15	Week 62	Memory Forensics Advanced (Training Images): Triage Workflows + Confidence	Memory analysis report (4–8 pages) + findin
Month 15	Week 63	Malware Triage (Defensive): YARA Advanced + Safe Workflow	YARA pack v2 (5 rules + results + FP notes)
Month 15	Week 64	DFIR Capstone: Full Investigation Case File (Training Datasets)	DFIR Case File v1 (12–25 pages + appendix
Month 16	Week 65	AWS Security Advanced (Concept + Lab): IAM, Logging, Detection	AWS baseline + logging matrix + IR mini pla
Month 16	Week 66	Azure Security Advanced (Concept): Entra ID, Sentinel, Monitoring	Azure baseline + detection ideas pack
Month 16	Week 67	Kubernetes Security (Concept + Practice): RBAC, Network Policies, Admission Controls	K8s hardening checklist + architecture diagram
Month 16	Week 68	IaC Security + Policy-as-Code Concepts: Terraform Scanning, Gates	IaC Security gates pack + IaC checklist
Month 17	Week 69	Governance & Risk: NIST RMF, Risk Register, Control Mapping	Risk register + control mapping workbook
Month 17	Week 70	Compliance & Audit Readiness: ISO 27001 Concepts + Evidence Packs	Policy pack (5) + audit evidence checklist
Month 17	Week 71	Zero Trust Architecture: Design, Segmentation, Identity-Centric Security	Zero Trust architecture document + control c
Month 17	Week 72	Security Architecture Capstone: End-to-End Secure Design	Security Design Document (15–30 pages) +
Month 18	Week 73	Application Security Leadership: Secure SDLC + ASVS + Code Review Concepts	AppSec Policy pack + review notes report
Month 18	Week 74	Threat Intelligence Operations: Intel Cycle + Reporting	Threat intel brief pack (2) + indicators templa
Month 18	Week 75	Red Team Program (High-Level, Authorized): Scoping, Rules, Reporting	R.T.E. engagement plan + reporting temp
Month 18	Week 76	Blue Team Program: SOC Maturity, Metrics, SLAs, Coverage Mapping	SOC maturity report + metrics/coverage pac
Month 18	Week 77	Elite Capstone Build I: Choose Specialization and Build Master Artifact	Master Capstone Artifact v1 (20–40 pages + append
Month 18	Week 78	Elite Capstone Delivery II: Portfolio Release + Interview Prep	Portfolio v2 Release + interview pack + 90-d

5. Weekly Modules (Elite Track)

Each week includes an overview page and an execution page.

Module: Month 13 — Week 53

Endpoint Telemetry Deep Dive: Sysmon Config + Windows Security Logging

Elite analysts know exactly which logs matter and how to tune telemetry to reduce noise and increase signal.

Certification alignment: Security+ (defense), SOC/Detection path	Tools focus: Sysmon, Windows Event Logs, PowerShell

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: Sysmon configuration concepts, Windows Event IDs, log normalization, evidence discipline, tuning basics.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: Sysmon configuration concepts, Windows Event IDs, log normalization, evidence discipline, tuning basics.
- Complete labs: Tune Sysmon config in lab (safe) + generate test events, Export logs and build a mini timeline.
- Deliver artifact: Sysmon tuning notes + log export script + evidence pack.
- Produce scenario report: Write a detection proposal: suspicious process execution chain.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Sysmon tuning notes + log export script + evidence pack
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 53

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: Sysmon configuration concepts, Windows Event IDs, log normalization, evidence discipline, tuning basics (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Tune Sysmon config in lab (safe) + generate test events.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Tune Sysmon config in lab (safe) + generate test events	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Export logs and build a mini timeline	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Sysmon tuning notes + log export script + evidence pack	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Write a detection proposal: suspicious process execution chain	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Tune Sysmon config in lab (safe) + generate test events
- Lab: Export logs and build a mini timeline
- Build: Sysmon tuning notes + log export script + evidence pack
- Scenario: Write a detection proposal: suspicious process execution chain

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Endpoint Visibility & Tuning Service (Authorized)
- Market note: Organizations pay for improved telemetry and reduced false positives with clear documentation.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- Sysmon: https://learn.microsoft.com/sysinternals/downloads/sysmon
- Microsoft Learn: https://learn.microsoft.com/

Module: Month 13 — Week 54

Network Detections: Zeek/Suricata Tuning + Enrichment Concepts

Elite network defense requires metadata analysis, alert tuning, and context enrichment for investigations.

Certification alignment: SOC readiness	Tools focus: Zeek, Suricata, Wireshark

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: Zeek logs, Suricata rules concepts, DNS/TLS indicators, enrichment (WHOIS/GeoIP concept), noise reduction.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: Zeek logs, Suricata rules concepts, DNS/TLS indicators, enrichment (WHOIS/GeoIP concept), noise reduction.
- Complete labs: Analyze a sample PCAP with Zeek and build an IOC table, Tune alert review and document false positives.
- Deliver artifact: Network detection notes + IOC table + tuning log.
- Produce scenario report: Write a SOC triage note: suspicious DNS/TLS pattern case.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Network detection notes + IOC table + tuning log
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 54

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: Zeek logs, Suricata rules concepts, DNS/TLS indicators, enrichment (WHOIS/GeoIP concept), noise reduction (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Analyze a sample PCAP with Zeek and build an IOC table.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Analyze a sample PCAP with Zeek and build an IOC table	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Tune alert review and document false positives	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Network detection notes + IOC table + tuning log	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Write a SOC triage note: suspicious DNS/TLS pattern case	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Analyze a sample PCAP with Zeek and build an IOC table
- Lab: Tune alert review and document false positives
- Build: Network detection notes + IOC table + tuning log
- Scenario: Write a SOC triage note: suspicious DNS/TLS pattern case

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Network Detection & PCAP Analysis (Authorized)
- Market note: Evidence-based network investigation reports are a premium deliverable.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- Zeek: https://zeek.org/
- Suricata: https://suricata.io/
- Wireshark: https://www.wireshark.org/docs/

Module: Month 13 — Week 55

Detection Engineering II: Correlation, Severity Rubric, Runbooks

Elite detection engineering: correlation, triage steps, FP tuning, and metrics (precision/coverage).

Certification alignment: Detection engineering	Tools focus: Sigma (concept), SIEM queries, Runbooks

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: correlation ideas, severity rubric, runbook structure, false positive management, metrics.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: correlation ideas, severity rubric, runbook structure, false positive management, metrics.
- Complete labs: Write 5 detection rules (Sigma-style concept) + triage steps, Simulate tuning notes and edge cases.
- Deliver artifact: Detection Pack v2 (5 detections + runbooks + severity rubric).
- Produce scenario report: Run alert triage simulation and document decisions.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Detection Pack v2 (5 detections + runbooks + severity rubric)
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 55

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: correlation ideas, severity rubric, runbook structure, false positive management, metrics (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Write 5 detection rules (Sigma-style concept) + triage steps.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Write 5 detection rules (Sigma-style concept) + triage steps	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Simulate tuning notes and edge cases	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Detection Pack v2 (5 detections + runbooks + severity rubric)	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Run alert triage simulation and document decisions	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Write 5 detection rules (Sigma-style concept) + triage steps
- Lab: Simulate tuning notes and edge cases
- Build: Detection Pack v2 (5 detections + runbooks + severity rubric)
- Scenario: Run alert triage simulation and document decisions

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Detection Pack Delivery (Authorized)
- Market note: Detection content + runbooks is directly monetizable for SOC teams.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- SigmaHQ: https://github.com/SigmaHQ/sigma
- MITRE ATT&CK;: https://attack.mitre.org/

Module: Month 13 — Week 56

SOAR & Automation: Playbooks, APIs, Case Management (Concept + Build)

Elite teams automate repetitive work: enrichment, ticket creation, and standardized response actions.

Certification alignment: Security engineering	Tools focus: Python, APIs, Playbooks

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: SOAR concepts, playbook design, API automation, case documentation, audit trails.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: SOAR concepts, playbook design, API automation, case documentation, audit trails.
- Complete labs: Build a small automation script that enriches IOCs (safe), Create a playbook template and case workflow.
- Deliver artifact: Mini-SOAR playbook pack + automation script + sample case.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: IOC received → enrich → triage → response plan → report.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Mini-SOAR playbook pack + automation script + sample case
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 56

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: SOAR concepts, playbook design, API automation, case documentation, audit trails (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Build a small automation script that enriches IOCs (safe).	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Build a small automation script that enriches IOCs (safe)	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Create a playbook template and case workflow	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Mini-SOAR playbook pack + automation script + sample case	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: IOC received → enrich → triage → response plan → report	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Build a small automation script that enriches IOCs (safe)
- Lab: Create a playbook template and case workflow
- Build: Mini-SOAR playbook pack + automation script + sample case
- Scenario: Scenario: IOC received → enrich → triage → response plan → report

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Security Automation Service (Authorized)
- Market note: Automation and documentation reduce response time and scale analyst output.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- Python docs: https://docs.python.org/3/
- OWASP Logging guidance: https://cheatsheetseries.owasp.org/

Elite Consolidation (After Week 56) — Checkpoint 1 (After Detection + SOAR block)

Raise quality: redo labs, refactor artifacts, improve reports and evidence.

Mandatory Tasks

- Redo 5 high-value labs (timed; no notes).
- Polish 3 reports to client quality (exec clarity + evidence + remediation).
- Refactor 2 toolkits/detection packs and release as vX.Y.
- Create a skills matrix (what you can do, evidence links).
- Take a 120-question mixed test; record weak areas and plan.

Output Required

- Elite consolidation report (3–6 pages) + updated portfolio README.
- Pinned top 8 artifacts (reports, packs, capstones).
- Self-test score record + next-month improvement plan.

Module: Month 14 — Week 57

Threat Hunting II: Baselining, Hypothesis Hunts, Evidence Tables

Elite hunters baseline normal, test hypotheses, and communicate clearly with evidence tables and recommendations.

Certification alignment: SOC readiness	Tools focus: Queries, Evidence tables

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: baselining, hypothesis hunts, confidence levels, gap analysis, MITRE mapping.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: baselining, hypothesis hunts, confidence levels, gap analysis, MITRE mapping.
- Complete labs: Hunt 1: suspicious logons, Hunt 2: unusual DNS behavior.
- Deliver artifact: Hunt report pack (2 hunts + gap analysis).
- Produce scenario report: Propose 7 new detections from gaps found.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Hunt report pack (2 hunts + gap analysis)
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 57

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: baselining, hypothesis hunts, confidence levels, gap analysis, MITRE mapping (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Hunt 1: suspicious logons.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Hunt 1: suspicious logons	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Hunt 2: unusual DNS behavior	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Hunt report pack (2 hunts + gap analysis)	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Propose 7 new detections from gaps found	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Hunt 1: suspicious logons
- Lab: Hunt 2: unusual DNS behavior
- Build: Hunt report pack (2 hunts + gap analysis)
- Scenario: Propose 7 new detections from gaps found

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Threat Hunting Reporting (Authorized)
- Market note: Recurring hunts and reports are a real service for SOC teams.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- MITRE ATT&CK;: https://attack.mitre.org/
- NIST CSF: https://www.nist.gov/cyberframework

Module: Month 14 — Week 58

Threat Hunting III: Lateral Movement Indicators (Defense Focus)

Elite defenders recognize lateral movement patterns through logs and network metadata (defensive thinking).

Certification alignment: SOC readiness	Tools focus: Sysmon logs, Zeek logs

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: lateral movement indicators, admin share concepts (defense), remote execution patterns (concept), detections and response.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: lateral movement indicators, admin share concepts (defense), remote execution patterns (concept), detections and response.
- Complete labs: Build a detection idea list for lateral movement indicators, Create a runbook for suspicious admin activity.
- Deliver artifact: Lateral movement defense pack (detections + runbooks).
- Produce scenario report: Write a hunting report: suspicious admin account activity case.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Lateral movement defense pack (detections + runbooks)
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 58

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: lateral movement indicators, admin share concepts (defense), remote execution patterns (concept), detections and response (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Build a detection idea list for lateral movement indicators.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Build a detection idea list for lateral movement indicators	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Create a runbook for suspicious admin activity	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Lateral movement defense pack (detections + runbooks)	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Write a hunting report: suspicious admin account activity case	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Build a detection idea list for lateral movement indicators
- Lab: Create a runbook for suspicious admin activity
- Build: Lateral movement defense pack (detections + runbooks)
- Scenario: Write a hunting report: suspicious admin account activity case

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Defense Content Pack (Authorized)
- Market note: SOC teams pay for packaged detections + runbooks with evidence and tuning notes.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- MITRE ATT&CK;: https://attack.mitre.org/
- MITRE D3FEND: https://d3fend.mitre.org/

Module: Month 14 — Week 59

Incident Response Advanced: Crisis Comms, Severity, War Room Discipline

Elite incident response includes communication, decision logs, and coordinated containment with leadership updates.

Certification alignment: IR leadership	Tools focus: IR templates, Timelines

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: severity classification, stakeholder comms, decision log, containment strategy, post-incident review.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: severity classification, stakeholder comms, decision log, containment strategy, post-incident review.
- Complete labs: Run a tabletop IR exercise with timelines, Write incident report + exec updates.
- Deliver artifact: IR war room pack: timeline + decision log + comms templates.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: ransomware-like impact (training) → containment → recovery plan.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- IR war room pack: timeline + decision log + comms templates
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 59

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: severity classification, stakeholder comms, decision log, containment strategy, post-incident review (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Run a tabletop IR exercise with timelines.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Run a tabletop IR exercise with timelines	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Write incident report + exec updates	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	IR war room pack: timeline + decision log + comms templates	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: ransomware-like impact (training) → containment → recovery plan	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Run a tabletop IR exercise with timelines
- Lab: Write incident report + exec updates
- Build: IR war room pack: timeline + decision log + comms templates
- Scenario: Scenario: ransomware-like impact (training) → containment → recovery plan

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: IR Program Support (Authorized)
- Market note: Organizations pay for IR readiness, playbooks, and realistic tabletop facilitation.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- NIST 800-61: https://csrc.nist.gov/publications/detail/sp/800-61/rev-2/final

Module: Month 14 — Week 60

SOC/IR Capstone: Full Case File (Alert → Investigation → Report)

Elite case handling: triage, investigation, evidence handling, and a complete report with recommendations.

Certification alignment: IR readiness	Tools focus: Logs, Case files, Reporting

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: case management, evidence integrity, report quality, remediation verification.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: case management, evidence integrity, report quality, remediation verification.
- Complete labs: Simulate 2 cases using lab logs or training datasets, Build full case file with appendix.
- Deliver artifact: SOC/IR Case File v2 (10–20 pages + evidence appendix).
- Produce scenario report: Executive briefing (1 page) + 5-minute script.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- SOC/IR Case File v2 (10–20 pages + evidence appendix)
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 60

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: case management, evidence integrity, report quality, remediation verification (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Simulate 2 cases using lab logs or training datasets.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Simulate 2 cases using lab logs or training datasets	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Build full case file with appendix	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	SOC/IR Case File v2 (10–20 pages + evidence appendix)	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Executive briefing (1 page) + 5-minute script	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Simulate 2 cases using lab logs or training datasets
- Lab: Build full case file with appendix
- Build: SOC/IR Case File v2 (10–20 pages + evidence appendix)
- Scenario: Executive briefing (1 page) + 5-minute script

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: SOC Case Management (Authorized)
- Market note: Complete case files are premium portfolio assets and paid deliverables.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- NIST 800-61: https://csrc.nist.gov/publications/detail/sp/800-61/rev-2/final
- MITRE ATT&CK;: https://attack.mitre.org/

Module: Month 15 — Week 61

Windows DFIR Advanced: Persistence & Artifact Deep Dive (Defense)

Elite DFIR requires understanding persistence locations and artifact triage (defensive, training datasets).

Certification alignment: DFIR readiness	Tools focus: Sysinternals, PowerShell

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: persistence concepts, registry artifacts (concept), scheduled tasks (concept), event logs, timeline building.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: persistence concepts, registry artifacts (concept), scheduled tasks (concept), event logs, timeline building.
- Complete labs: Collect artifacts in lab and build a detailed timeline table, Document top persistence locations to monitor.
- Deliver artifact: DFIR artifact checklist + timeline report.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: suspicious persistence indicators → triage and containment plan.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- DFIR artifact checklist + timeline report
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 61

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: persistence concepts, registry artifacts (concept), scheduled tasks (concept), event logs, timeline building (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Collect artifacts in lab and build a detailed timeline table.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Collect artifacts in lab and build a detailed timeline table	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Document top persistence locations to monitor	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	DFIR artifact checklist + timeline report	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: suspicious persistence indicators → triage and containment plan	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Collect artifacts in lab and build a detailed timeline table
- Lab: Document top persistence locations to monitor
- Build: DFIR artifact checklist + timeline report
- Scenario: Scenario: suspicious persistence indicators → triage and containment plan

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: DFIR Triage & Reporting (Authorized)
- Market note: DFIR reports with timelines and recommendations are premium services.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- Sysinternals: https://learn.microsoft.com/sysinternals/
- MITRE ATT&CK;: https://attack.mitre.org/

Module: Month 15 — Week 62

Memory Forensics Advanced (Training Images): Triage Workflow + Confidence

Elite memory triage: process, network connections, injected modules (concept), and structured reporting.

Certification alignment: DFIR readiness	Tools focus: Volatility, Reporting

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: Volatility workflow, triage methodology, confidence levels, report structure.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: Volatility workflow, triage methodology, confidence levels, report structure.
- Complete labs: Analyze a training memory image and produce structured findings, Build a findings table with confidence ratings.
- Deliver artifact: Memory analysis report (4–8 pages) + findings table.
- Produce scenario report: Map findings to ATT&CK; techniques (concept) and propose detections.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Memory analysis report (4–8 pages) + findings table
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 62

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: Volatility workflow, triage methodology, confidence levels, report structure (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Analyze a training memory image and produce structured findings.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Analyze a training memory image and produce structured findings	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Build a findings table with confidence ratings	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Memory analysis report (4–8 pages) + findings table	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Map findings to ATT&CK; techniques (concept) and propose detections	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Analyze a training memory image and produce structured findings
- Lab: Build a findings table with confidence ratings
- Build: Memory analysis report (4–8 pages) + findings table
- Scenario: Map findings to ATT&CK; techniques (concept) and propose detections

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Memory Analysis Reporting (Authorized)
- Market note: Memory analysis reporting is rare and valuable in DFIR roles.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- Volatility: https://www.volatilityfoundation.org/
- MITRE ATT&CK;: https://attack.mitre.org/

Module: Month 15 — Week 63

Malware Triage (Defensive): YARA Advanced + Safe Workflow

Elite defensive analysis: indicators, behavior notes, YARA rules, and detection recommendations.

Certification alignment: Detection/DFIR	Tools focus: YARA, Hashing, Sandbox concepts

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: YARA rule quality, indicator extraction, safe workflows, reporting.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: YARA rule quality, indicator extraction, safe workflows, reporting.
- Complete labs: Write 5 YARA rules for training samples, Build results table and false positive notes.
- Deliver artifact: YARA pack v2 (5 rules + results + FP notes).
- Produce scenario report: Write a malware triage report template and one sample report.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- YARA pack v2 (5 rules + results + FP notes)
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 63

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: YARA rule quality, indicator extraction, safe workflows, reporting (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Write 5 YARA rules for training samples.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Write 5 YARA rules for training samples	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Build results table and false positive notes	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	YARA pack v2 (5 rules + results + FP notes)	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Write a malware triage report template and one sample report	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Write 5 YARA rules for training samples
- Lab: Build results table and false positive notes
- Build: YARA pack v2 (5 rules + results + FP notes)
- Scenario: Write a malware triage report template and one sample report

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Defensive Detection Content (Authorized)
- Market note: Detection content packs (YARA) plus documentation are sellable assets.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- YARA: https://virustotal.github.io/yara/
- CISA: https://www.cisa.gov/

Module: Month 15 — Week 64

DFIR Capstone: Full Investigation Case File (Training Dataset)

Elite DFIR capstone: triage, timeline, indicators, and a professional report with recommendations and gaps.

Certification alignment: DFIR readiness	Tools focus: Evidence management, Reporting

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: evidence integrity, timeline, IOCs, recommendations, lessons learned.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: evidence integrity, timeline, IOCs, recommendations, lessons learned.
- Complete labs: Analyze a training dataset (logs + artifacts), Produce a full case file with appendix.
- Deliver artifact: DFIR Case File v1 (12–25 pages + appendix).
- Produce scenario report: Executive summary + containment recommendations.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- DFIR Case File v1 (12–25 pages + appendix)
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 64

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: evidence integrity, timeline, IOCs, recommendations, lessons learned (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Analyze a training dataset (logs + artifacts).	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Analyze a training dataset (logs + artifacts)	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Produce a full case file with appendix	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	DFIR Case File v1 (12–25 pages + appendix)	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Executive summary + containment recommendations	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Analyze a training dataset (logs + artifacts)
- Lab: Produce a full case file with appendix
- Build: DFIR Case File v1 (12–25 pages + appendix)
- Scenario: Executive summary + containment recommendations

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: DFIR Case Delivery (Authorized)
- Market note: Full case files convert to top-tier DFIR roles and contracts.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- NIST 800-61: https://csrc.nist.gov/publications/detail/sp/800-61/rev-2/final

Elite Consolidation (After Week 64) — Checkpoint 2 (After DFIR Capstone block)

Raise quality: redo labs, refactor artifacts, improve reports and evidence.

Mandatory Tasks

- Redo 5 high-value labs (timed; no notes).
- Polish 3 reports to client quality (exec clarity + evidence + remediation).
- Refactor 2 toolkits/detection packs and release as vX.Y.
- Create a skills matrix (what you can do, evidence links).
- Take a 120-question mixed test; record weak areas and plan.

Output Required

- Elite consolidation report (3–6 pages) + updated portfolio README.
- Pinned top 8 artifacts (reports, packs, capstones).
- Self-test score record + next-month improvement plan.

Module: Month 16 — Week 65

AWS Security Advanced (Concept + Lab): IAM, Logging, Detection

Elite cloud security: least privilege, audit logs, detections, and incident response planning.

Certification alignment: Cloud security	Tools focus: AWS concepts, IAM, Logging

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: IAM policy evaluation, CloudTrail concepts, GuardDuty concepts, alerting strategy, IR playbooks.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: IAM policy evaluation, CloudTrail concepts, GuardDuty concepts, alerting strategy, IR playbooks.
- Complete labs: Create AWS baseline checklist, Draft logging matrix and alert triage steps.
- Deliver artifact: AWS baseline + logging matrix + IR mini playbook.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: suspected key compromise (training) → response plan.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- AWS baseline + logging matrix + IR mini playbook
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 65

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: IAM policy evaluation, CloudTrail concepts, GuardDuty concepts, alerting strategy, IR playbooks (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Create AWS baseline checklist.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Create AWS baseline checklist	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Draft logging matrix and alert triage steps	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	AWS baseline + logging matrix + IR mini playbook	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: suspected key compromise (training) → response plan	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Create AWS baseline checklist
- Lab: Draft logging matrix and alert triage steps
- Build: AWS baseline + logging matrix + IR mini playbook
- Scenario: Scenario: suspected key compromise (training) → response plan

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Cloud Baseline Review (Authorized)
- Market note: Cloud baseline reviews and logging matrices are high-demand deliverables.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- AWS Security: https://docs.aws.amazon.com/security/
- AWS CloudTrail: https://docs.aws.amazon.com/awscloudtrail/

Module: Month 16 — Week 66

Azure Security Advanced (Concept): Entra ID, Sentinel, Monitoring

Elite Azure security: identity, monitoring, detection and response thinking.

Certification alignment: Cloud security	Tools focus: Azure concepts, Monitoring

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: Entra ID concepts, Azure Monitor concepts, Sentinel concepts, logging and alerting strategy.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: Entra ID concepts, Azure Monitor concepts, Sentinel concepts, logging and alerting strategy.
- Complete labs: Create Azure baseline checklist, Draft 6 detection ideas and triage steps (concept).
- Deliver artifact: Azure baseline + detection ideas pack.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: suspicious sign-ins (training) → triage + response plan.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Azure baseline + detection ideas pack
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 66

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: Entra ID concepts, Azure Monitor concepts, Sentinel concepts, logging and alerting strategy (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Create Azure baseline checklist.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Create Azure baseline checklist	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Draft 6 detection ideas and triage steps (concept)	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Azure baseline + detection ideas pack	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: suspicious sign-ins (training) → triage + response plan	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Create Azure baseline checklist
- Lab: Draft 6 detection ideas and triage steps (concept)
- Build: Azure baseline + detection ideas pack
- Scenario: Scenario: suspicious sign-ins (training) → triage + response plan

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Cloud Detection Content (Authorized)
- Market note: Detection ideas and runbooks mapped to cloud telemetry are valuable to SOC teams.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- Azure Security: https://learn.microsoft.com/azure/security/
- Microsoft Sentinel: https://learn.microsoft.com/azure/sentinel/

Module: Month 16 — Week 67

Kubernetes Security (Concept + Practice): RBAC, Network Policies, Admission Controls

Elite container platforms require security controls: identity, policy, segmentation, and monitoring.

Certification alignment: Cloud/DevSecOps	Tools focus: Kubernetes concepts, Policy

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: RBAC concepts, network policies, secrets hygiene, runtime hardening concepts, logging.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: RBAC concepts, network policies, secrets hygiene, runtime hardening concepts, logging.
- Complete labs: Build a K8s security baseline checklist, Draft an incident scenario response note.
- Deliver artifact: K8s baseline checklist + architecture diagram.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: exposed service (training) → containment and hardening plan.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- K8s baseline checklist + architecture diagram
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 67

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: RBAC concepts, network policies, secrets hygiene, runtime hardening concepts, logging (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Build a K8s security baseline checklist.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Build a K8s security baseline checklist	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Draft an incident scenario response note	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	K8s baseline checklist + architecture diagram	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: exposed service (training) → containment and hardening plan	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Build a K8s security baseline checklist
- Lab: Draft an incident scenario response note
- Build: K8s baseline checklist + architecture diagram
- Scenario: Scenario: exposed service (training) → containment and hardening plan

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Kubernetes Baseline Guidance (Authorized)
- Market note: Teams pay for Kubernetes baseline reviews and policy documentation.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- Kubernetes docs: https://kubernetes.io/docs/
- CIS Benchmarks: https://www.cisecurity.org/benchmarks

Module: Month 16 — Week 68

IaC Security + Policy-as-Code Concepts: Terraform Scanning, Controls

Elite security engineers shift left: IaC scanning, policy gates, and secure CI/CD controls.

Certification alignment: Security engineering	Tools focus: IaC concepts, DevSecOps

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: IaC risks, policy-as-code concepts, SAST/DAST concepts, secret scanning.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: IaC risks, policy-as-code concepts, SAST/DAST concepts, secret scanning.
- Complete labs: Draft IaC security checklist, Design pipeline security gates (concept).
- Deliver artifact: DevSecOps gate pack + IaC checklist.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: misconfiguration risk identified pre-deploy → remediation workflow.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- DevSecOps gate pack + IaC checklist
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 68

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: IaC risks, policy-as-code concepts, SAST/DAST concepts, secret scanning (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Draft IaC security checklist.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Draft IaC security checklist	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Design pipeline security gates (concept)	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	DevSecOps gate pack + IaC checklist	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: misconfiguration risk identified pre-deploy → remediation workflow	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Draft IaC security checklist
- Lab: Design pipeline security gates (concept)
- Build: DevSecOps gate pack + IaC checklist
- Scenario: Scenario: misconfiguration risk identified pre-deploy → remediation workflow

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: DevSecOps Policy Delivery (Authorized)
- Market note: Policy packs and security gates help teams prevent incidents and are sellable deliverables.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- OWASP ASVS: https://owasp.org/www-project-application-security-verification-standard/
- OWASP Cheat Sheets: https://cheatsheetseries.owasp.org/

Module: Month 17 — Week 69

Governance & Risk: NIST RMF, Risk Register, Control Mapping

Elite security includes governance: risk registers, control mapping, and audit-ready evidence.

Certification alignment: GRC readiness	Tools focus: Documentation, Risk register

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: NIST RMF concepts, risk register, control mapping, evidence collection.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: NIST RMF concepts, risk register, control mapping, evidence collection.
- Complete labs: Build a risk register for your lab environment, Map top 20 controls to your environment.
- Deliver artifact: Risk register + control mapping workbook.
- Produce scenario report: Write a management briefing: top risks and mitigation plan.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Risk register + control mapping workbook
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 69

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: NIST RMF concepts, risk register, control mapping, evidence collection (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Build a risk register for your lab environment.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Build a risk register for your lab environment	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Map top 20 controls to your environment	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Risk register + control mapping workbook	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Write a management briefing: top risks and mitigation plan	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Build a risk register for your lab environment
- Lab: Map top 20 controls to your environment
- Build: Risk register + control mapping workbook
- Scenario: Write a management briefing: top risks and mitigation plan

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Risk Assessment Service (Authorized)
- Market note: Risk registers and control mapping are paid work in government and enterprise.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- NIST CSF: https://www.nist.gov/cyberframework
- NIST RMF: https://csrc.nist.gov/projects/risk-management

Module: Month 17 — Week 70

Compliance & Audit Readiness: ISO 27001 Concepts + Evidence Packs

Elite professionals can support audits with clear evidence, policies, and process documentation.

Certification alignment: GRC readiness	Tools focus: Policies, Evidence packs

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: ISO 27001 concepts, policy writing, audit evidence, logging retention.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: ISO 27001 concepts, policy writing, audit evidence, logging retention.
- Complete labs: Write 5 core policies (draft), Build an evidence pack structure.
- Deliver artifact: Policy pack (5) + audit evidence checklist.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: audit request → evidence response plan.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Policy pack (5) + audit evidence checklist
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 70

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: ISO 27001 concepts, policy writing, audit evidence, logging retention (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Write 5 core policies (draft).	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Write 5 core policies (draft)	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Build an evidence pack structure	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Policy pack (5) + audit evidence checklist	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: audit request → evidence response plan	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Write 5 core policies (draft)
- Lab: Build an evidence pack structure
- Build: Policy pack (5) + audit evidence checklist
- Scenario: Scenario: audit request → evidence response plan

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Audit Preparation Support (Authorized)
- Market note: Policy writing and audit readiness support are monetizable professional services.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- ISO overview: https://www.iso.org/isoiec-27001-information-security.html
- NIST CSF: https://www.nist.gov/cyberframework

Module: Month 17 — Week 71

Zero Trust Architecture: Design, Segmentation, Identity-Centric Security

Elite architecture: explain and design Zero Trust with diagrams and measurable controls.

Certification alignment: Architecture readiness	Tools focus: Architecture diagrams, Identity controls

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: Zero Trust pillars, least privilege, segmentation, continuous verification, monitoring.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: Zero Trust pillars, least privilege, segmentation, continuous verification, monitoring.
- Complete labs: Design a zero trust plan for a sample org, Create a control checklist and metrics.
- Deliver artifact: Zero Trust architecture document + control checklist.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: breach assumed → design containment and verification controls.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Zero Trust architecture document + control checklist
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 71

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: Zero Trust pillars, least privilege, segmentation, continuous verification, monitoring (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Design a zero trust plan for a sample org.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Design a zero trust plan for a sample org	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Create a control checklist and metrics	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Zero Trust architecture document + control checklist	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: breach assumed → design containment and verification controls	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Design a zero trust plan for a sample org
- Lab: Create a control checklist and metrics
- Build: Zero Trust architecture document + control checklist
- Scenario: Scenario: breach assumed → design containment and verification controls

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Security Architecture Consulting (Authorized)
- Market note: Architecture diagrams + controls + metrics are high-value deliverables.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- NIST Zero Trust: https://csrc.nist.gov/publications/detail/sp/800-207/final

Module: Month 17 — Week 72

Security Architecture Capstone: End-to-End Secure Design Document

Elite capstone: produce a full security design document for an enterprise-like system.

Certification alignment: Architecture readiness	Tools focus: Diagrams, Threat modeling

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: secure architecture, threat modeling (concept), logging strategy, IR readiness, data protection.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: secure architecture, threat modeling (concept), logging strategy, IR readiness, data protection.
- Complete labs: Create architecture diagram + trust boundaries, Write design doc with controls and rationale.
- Deliver artifact: Security Design Document (15–30 pages) + diagrams.
- Produce scenario report: Executive briefing (2 pages) for leadership.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Security Design Document (15–30 pages) + diagrams
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 72

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: secure architecture, threat modeling (concept), logging strategy, IR readiness, data protection (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Create architecture diagram + trust boundaries.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Create architecture diagram + trust boundaries	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Write design doc with controls and rationale	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Security Design Document (15–30 pages) + diagrams	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Executive briefing (2 pages) for leadership	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Create architecture diagram + trust boundaries
- Lab: Write design doc with controls and rationale
- Build: Security Design Document (15–30 pages) + diagrams
- Scenario: Executive briefing (2 pages) for leadership

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Architecture Design Delivery (Authorized)
- Market note: A strong design document is a flagship portfolio piece for senior roles.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- OWASP Threat Modeling: https://cheatsheetseries.owasp.org/cheatsheets/Threat_Modeling_Cheat_Sheet.html
- NIST 800-61: https://csrc.nist.gov/publications/detail/sp/800-61/rev-2/final

Elite Consolidation (After Week 72) — Checkpoint 3 (After Architecture Capstone block)

Raise quality: redo labs, refactor artifacts, improve reports and evidence.

Mandatory Tasks

- Redo 5 high-value labs (timed; no notes).
- Polish 3 reports to client quality (exec clarity + evidence + remediation).
- Refactor 2 toolkits/detection packs and release as vX.Y.
- Create a skills matrix (what you can do, evidence links).
- Take a 120-question mixed test; record weak areas and plan.

Output Required

- Elite consolidation report (3–6 pages) + updated portfolio README.
- Pinned top 8 artifacts (reports, packs, capstones).
- Self-test score record + next-month improvement plan.

Module: Month 18 — Week 73

Application Security Leadership: Secure SDLC + ASVS + Code Review Concepts

Elite AppSec: you can guide teams with checklists, gates, and review discipline (concept + practice).

Certification alignment: AppSec readiness	Tools focus: ASVS, Secure SDLC

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: secure SDLC, ASVS concepts, code review approach, SAST/DAST concepts, secure defaults.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: secure SDLC, ASVS concepts, code review approach, SAST/DAST concepts, secure defaults.
- Complete labs: Build an ASVS-based checklist subset, Apply checklist to a demo repo (review notes).
- Deliver artifact: AppSec checklist pack + review notes report.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: release readiness review → approve/deny with evidence.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- AppSec checklist pack + review notes report
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 73

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: secure SDLC, ASVS concepts, code review approach, SAST/DAST concepts, secure defaults (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Build an ASVS-based checklist subset.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Build an ASVS-based checklist subset	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Apply checklist to a demo repo (review notes)	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	AppSec checklist pack + review notes report	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: release readiness review → approve/deny with evidence	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Build an ASVS-based checklist subset
- Lab: Apply checklist to a demo repo (review notes)
- Build: AppSec checklist pack + review notes report
- Scenario: Scenario: release readiness review → approve/deny with evidence

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: AppSec Review Service (Authorized)
- Market note: Release readiness reviews and checklists are paid consulting work.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- OWASP ASVS: https://owasp.org/www-project-application-security-verification-standard/
- OWASP Cheat Sheets: https://cheatsheetseries.owasp.org/

Module: Month 18 — Week 74

Threat Intelligence Operations: Intel Cycle + Reporting

Elite teams use intel to prioritize risk. Learn the intel cycle and write briefs that leadership understands.

Certification alignment: Threat intel readiness	Tools focus: Intel briefs, OSINT (authorized)

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: intel cycle, collection/processing, analysis, dissemination, confidence ratings.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: intel cycle, collection/processing, analysis, dissemination, confidence ratings.
- Complete labs: Write 2 intel briefs from public sources (no sensitive data), Create an indicators table template.
- Deliver artifact: Threat intel brief pack (2) + indicators template.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: new threat advisory → internal briefing + detection recommendations.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Threat intel brief pack (2) + indicators template
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 74

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: intel cycle, collection/processing, analysis, dissemination, confidence ratings (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Write 2 intel briefs from public sources (no sensitive data).	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Write 2 intel briefs from public sources (no sensitive data)	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Create an indicators table template	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Threat intel brief pack (2) + indicators template	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: new threat advisory → internal briefing + detection recommendations	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Write 2 intel briefs from public sources (no sensitive data)
- Lab: Create an indicators table template
- Build: Threat intel brief pack (2) + indicators template
- Scenario: Scenario: new threat advisory → internal briefing + detection recommendations

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Threat Intel Briefing (Authorized)
- Market note: Clear intel briefs help leadership prioritize controls; this is a premium communication skill.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- CISA: https://www.cisa.gov/
- MITRE ATT&CK;: https://attack.mitre.org/

Module: Month 18 — Week 75

Red Team Program (High-Level, Authorized): Scoping, RoE, Reporting

Elite red team capability is driven by planning, safety, and reporting (no unauthorized activity).

Certification alignment: Professional ethics	Tools focus: Scoping, Reporting

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: rules of engagement, scope and authorization, evidence handling, risk communication.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: rules of engagement, scope and authorization, evidence handling, risk communication.
- Complete labs: Draft a red team engagement plan (template), Create a reporting format and evidence appendix.
- Deliver artifact: Red team engagement plan + reporting template.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: client request → scope negotiation and safe plan.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Red team engagement plan + reporting template
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 75

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: rules of engagement, scope and authorization, evidence handling, risk communication (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Draft a red team engagement plan (template).	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Draft a red team engagement plan (template)	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Create a reporting format and evidence appendix	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Red team engagement plan + reporting template	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: client request → scope negotiation and safe plan	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Draft a red team engagement plan (template)
- Lab: Create a reporting format and evidence appendix
- Build: Red team engagement plan + reporting template
- Scenario: Scenario: client request → scope negotiation and safe plan

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Assessment Planning Service (Authorized)
- Market note: Scoping and reporting are valuable and safe skills you can monetize without unethical actions.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- OWASP Testing Guide: https://owasp.org/www-project-web-security-testing-guide/

Module: Month 18 — Week 76

Blue Team Program: SOC Maturity, Metrics, SLAs, Coverage Mapping

Elite blue teams measure effectiveness: coverage, precision, MTTR, and runbook maturity.

Certification alignment: SOC leadership	Tools focus: Metrics, Coverage maps

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: SOC maturity models (concept), metrics (MTTD/MTTR), coverage mapping, SLAs/runbooks.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: SOC maturity models (concept), metrics (MTTD/MTTR), coverage mapping, SLAs/runbooks.
- Complete labs: Build a SOC maturity assessment for your lab, Create a coverage map + metrics dashboard spec.
- Deliver artifact: SOC maturity report + metrics/coverage pack.
- Produce scenario report: Scenario: leadership asks 'are we safe?' → answer with metrics and gaps.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- SOC maturity report + metrics/coverage pack
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 76

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: SOC maturity models (concept), metrics (MTTD/MTTR), coverage mapping, SLAs/runbooks (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Build a SOC maturity assessment for your lab.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Build a SOC maturity assessment for your lab	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Create a coverage map + metrics dashboard spec	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	SOC maturity report + metrics/coverage pack	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Scenario: leadership asks 'are we safe?' → answer with metrics and gaps	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Build a SOC maturity assessment for your lab
- Lab: Create a coverage map + metrics dashboard spec
- Build: SOC maturity report + metrics/coverage pack
- Scenario: Scenario: leadership asks 'are we safe?' → answer with metrics and gaps

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: SOC Program Consulting (Authorized)
- Market note: SOC maturity assessments and metrics packs are paid work in mature orgs.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- MITRE ATT&CK;: https://attack.mitre.org/
- NIST CSF: https://www.nist.gov/cyberframework

Module: Month 18 — Week 77

Elite Capstone Build I: Choose Specialization and Build Master Artifact

Elite capstone: choose your track (Detection/DFIR/Cloud/AppSec/Architecture) and build a flagship project.

Certification alignment: Professional readiness	Tools focus: Portfolio, Reporting

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: capstone planning, evidence management, high-quality reporting, presentation.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: capstone planning, evidence management, high-quality reporting, presentation.
- Complete labs: Build master artifact and documentation, Prepare presentation materials.
- Deliver artifact: Master Capstone v1 (20–40 pages + appendix + artifacts).
- Produce scenario report: Mock panel review: present the capstone and defend decisions.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Master Capstone v1 (20–40 pages + appendix + artifacts)
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 77

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: capstone planning, evidence management, high-quality reporting, presentation (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Build master artifact and documentation.	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Build master artifact and documentation	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Prepare presentation materials	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Master Capstone v1 (20–40 pages + appendix + artifacts)	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Mock panel review: present the capstone and defend decisions	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Build master artifact and documentation
- Lab: Prepare presentation materials
- Build: Master Capstone v1 (20–40 pages + appendix + artifacts)
- Scenario: Mock panel review: present the capstone and defend decisions

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Elite Portfolio Project (Authorized)
- Market note: Flagship capstones are what separates elite candidates.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- NIST 800-61: https://csrc.nist.gov/publications/detail/sp/800-61/rev-2/final

Module: Month 18 — Week 78

Elite Capstone Delivery II: Portfolio Release + Interview/Negotiation Pack

Finish elite: publish portfolio v2.0, prepare interviews, and build a 90-day on-the-job plan.

Certification alignment: Job readiness	Tools focus: CV, Interview pack

Key Notes (Elite Standard)

- Elite focus topics: portfolio release, interview strategy, negotiation basics, 90-day plan.
- Quality standard: every output must be client-ready (clear, complete, reproducible).
- Professional reporting required weekly (2–8 pages depending on complexity).
- No real-world targeting. Lab-only unless written authorization.

Learning Outcomes

- Demonstrate: portfolio release, interview strategy, negotiation basics, 90-day plan.
- Complete labs: Finalize portfolio (pinned artifacts), Create interview Q&A; pack (60) + 90-day plan.
- Deliver artifact: Portfolio v2.0 release + interview pack + 90-day plan.
- Produce scenario report: Mock interview: case presentation + architecture briefing.
- Update portfolio with evidence and README.

Required Artifact (Flagship Output)

- Portfolio v2.0 release + interview pack + 90-day plan
- Evidence + README required.
- Professional report required (3–10 pages).

Execution Plan — Week 78

2 theory days maximum; practical + reporting dominates.

Daily Plan (Mon–Sat study | Sun revision)

Day	Theory Focus	Hands-On Lab	Deliverable / Proof
Mon (Theory)	Theory: portfolio release, interview strategy, negotiation basics, 90-day plan (concepts + risks + controls).	Guided mini-lab: start Finalize portfolio (pinned artifacts).	Notes + evidence.
Tue (Theory)	Theory: metrics/tuning/testing and how to communicate outcomes.	Write a checklist + 15-question quiz.	Checklist + score.
Wed (Practical)	Lab 1 (core).	Finalize portfolio (pinned artifacts)	Writeup + evidence.
Thu (Practical)	Lab 2 (advanced).	Create interview Q&A; pack (60) + 90-day plan	Tool log + evidence.
Fri (Practical)	Build day: artifact production and packaging.	Portfolio v2.0 release + interview pack + 90-day plan	Artifact + README + sample output.
Sat (Practical)	Scenario + report day.	Mock interview: case presentation + architecture briefing	Report (3–10 pages).
Sun (Revision)	Revision: redo 1 lab without notes + test.	Redo lab + 40-question test.	Score + improvements list.

Lab Tasks (Required)

- Lab: Finalize portfolio (pinned artifacts)
- Lab: Create interview Q&A; pack (60) + 90-day plan
- Build: Portfolio v2.0 release + interview pack + 90-day plan
- Scenario: Mock interview: case presentation + architecture briefing

Exercises

- Write an executive brief (1 page) and a technical appendix (1–2 pages).
- Create a coverage map or checklist for the week (what is covered and what is not).
- Add 20 practice questions with answers.
- Refactor one older artifact to improve clarity, structure, and evidence.

Platform Targets

- TryHackMe/HTB: 1 aligned module (advanced).
- If web topic: 1 PortSwigger lab (intermediate).
- Save proof screenshots + notes to portfolio.

Money-Generating Concept (Authorized)

- Skill: Job Conversion (Authorized)
- Market note: Elite packaging converts skill to high-paying roles.
- Start: Offer authorized services: assessment + evidence + report + remediation or runbook pack.

References

- GitHub Docs: https://docs.github.com/
- NIST CSF: https://www.nist.gov/cyberframework

Appendix A — Metrics and Coverage Template (Elite SOC)

Metric	Definition / Guidance
MTTD	Mean Time To Detect; measure detection speed.
MTTR	Mean Time To Respond; measure response speed.
Precision	How many alerts are true positives vs noise.
Coverage	Which ATT&CK techniques are detected/monitored.
Control Effectiveness	Evidence that controls reduce risk (before/after).
Reporting Cadence	Weekly/monthly briefings; track improvements over time.

Appendix B — Executive Brief Template

Section	What to write
Situation	What happened or what risk exists.
Impact	Business impact (CIA) and urgency.
Evidence	Key evidence in plain language.
Recommendation	Top 3 actions to reduce risk.
Status/Next Steps	What is done and what will be done next.

Appendix C — Security Design Doc Template

Section	What to include
System Overview	Purpose, components, data flows.
Trust Boundaries	Where trust changes; attach diagram.
Threat Model (Concept)	Top threats and assumptions.
Controls	Identity, network, data, monitoring, response.
Logging/Monitoring	What is logged, retention, alerts.
Incident Response	Playbooks and escalation paths.
Risk Register	Top risks, likelihood, impact, mitigation.